The Effect of Third-Party Vendor Vulnerabilities:

2025 Ericsson Service Provider Breach

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ITSY 1342: Information Technology Security

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April 16, 2026

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As technology continues to advance, cybersecurity attacks increase. This includes a common attack today: vishing attacks, or voice phishing. Vishing has been increasing as a form of social engineering since it takes advantage of the human element of an organization's security posture (CISA, 2021). Instead of exploiting software vulnerabilities, vishing attacks manipulate individuals into providing credentials or sensitive information, making them especially dangerous in environments where third-party vendors handle sensitive data on behalf of larger organizations.

In April 2025, an attacker called an employee at a service provider of Ericsson Inc. (Mascellino, 2026). This call gained unauthorized access to data between April 17 and April 22, 2025. Despite the breach occurring in 2025, affected individuals were not notified until March 2026. This lapse highlights failures in incident response, third-party oversight, and compliance with federal cybersecurity frameworks. This paper examines the technical failures behind the Ericsson service provider breach, analyzes how it impacted the CIA triad, and proposes security improvements.

Incident Background

The date the cybersecurity breach first compromised the vendor’s information was on April 17, 2025. The threat actor had access to Ericsson’s data from April 17 to April 22, 2025. It was not until April 28 that the service provider became aware of the incident (Office of the Maine AG, 2025). Once aware, the service provider then brought in outside cybersecurity

experts, forced password resets, and notified the FBI while conducting a comprehensive review to determine what information had been accessed and who was affected (van Klinken, 2026).

The breach affected 15,661 individuals altogether. Texas regulators confirmed that the compromised data included names, addresses, Social Security numbers, driver's license numbers, government-issued ID numbers, financial information, medical information, and dates of birth (Gatlan, 2026). Despite the breach occurring in April 2025, the service provider did not notify Ericsson until November 10, 2025, seven months after the fact. It then took Ericsson an additional three months to identify all affected individuals, with official notifications going out March 9, 2026. This eleven-month gap between breach and public notification is a significant compliance failure on its own.

CIA Triad Analysis

With the breach exposing personal information of thousands of individuals, this is a direct display of lack of confidentiality protection. With a lack of multi-factor authentication, this allowed the vishing attack to occur as there were no safeguard measures in place to further authenticate the caller. There also is a need for increased employee education for cybersecurity so that the employees will be familiarized with what a vishing attack would look like, among other social engineering attack forms. Another way to further secure and prevent a breach like this, would be to implement least privileged access controls. This would have limited the attacker’s access even after credentials were compromised.

The breach not only has availability failures, but there are integrity gaps as well. Neither Ericsson nor its service provider has reported evidence of the misuse, or attempted misuse, of any potentially impacted information (Office of the Maine AG, 2025). There is no guarantee that

the threat actor did not modify any of the data they accessed, as once a threat actor has access to data there is no way to verify the data was altered. Since there was a seven-month delay from the attack to Ericsson's awareness, there is no reliable way to establish a clean baseline of what the data originally looked like. Integrity controls like implementing a SIEM for robust and timely audit logging would help this scenario against such threat actors and allow for Ericsson to be aware of the data compromise much sooner than seven months after the fact. Having proper protocols in place where there is routinely someone checking the logs would prevent a repeat incident and allow Ericsson to confirm if any documents and files had been altered.

Now looking at availability, there were forced password resets and system response measures after the incident which caused operational disruption (van Klinken, 2026). Since availability is ensuring that data and systems are accessible to authorized users, this disruption was a direct failure of availability. The company likely did not have an existing or familiarized incident response plan with third party vendors, allowing for an extended downtime in communication and response. Additionally, since there was an eleven-month notification delay, these individuals were unable to take immediate protective action. This meant they had their data security unavailable to them. Some ways to combat these availability vulnerabilities include developing or adding to the incident response plan for third party vendors and establishing proper protocols and procedures. Additionally, having network segmentation would help ensure that there was just a contained area breached, and limit the amount of information that got accessed.

Conclusion

The 2025 Ericsson service provider vishing attack is a great example of how a single social engineering attack can cause a widespread impact on an organization and the individuals it

serves. This breach is also a great display of how vishing attacks are on the rise, and how important it is to maintain a proper security structure. Ericsson would have been in a better position if they had a SIEM system to help maintain and monitor logs, security controls like multifactor authentication, and an extended policy in their incident response plan for third party vendors. Having these tools and procedures in place would help keep the company at a good position to protect against vishing attacks, along with other social engineering attacks.

References

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